

Protest and Elections

The Tet Offensive inflamed passions in the US, leading to widespread antiwar protests in the streets and on college campuses. These disturbances would spill over into the presidential election of 1968.

◀◀ BEFORE

The antiwar movement largely grew out of college campuses, where the radical Students for a Democratic Society (SDS) campaigned in the mid-1960s.

GROWING DISSENT

Before 1968, Americans **protested against the war** through campus teach-ins, draft resistance, and a large-scale march on Washington in 1967. Contemporary to the antiwar movement was the **Civil Rights Movement**, which also rocked the nation. Amid this growing turmoil, **Lyndon B. Johnson became president** in 1963, in the wake of the assassination of John F. Kennedy. Johnson would be elected president in his own right in 1964, in a **landslide victory**.

The year 1968 will go down as one of the most turbulent in US history: an emotional and sometimes violent confluence of war, politics, civil rights, and social revolution that rocked the country from coast to coast. In one protest, a full-page ad ran in the *New York Post*, *New York Review of Books*, and *Ramparts* magazine, explaining that nearly 530 writers and editors had pledged not to pay the 10 percent Vietnam War tax surcharge because they believed American participation in the war was "morally wrong." The list included Allen Ginsberg, Noam Chomsky, James Baldwin, and many other famous and influential writers who opposed the war.